

ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

Second Hand Fame

What's common between Uddhav Thackeray and Utsav Sharma? One defaces the poster of a hero and another defaces a villain? For both it's a cry for help? Yes. And yes again. The minute Thackeray questioned Shah Rukh Khan's patriotism, the media found itself split between the Mannat and Matoshree drawing rooms, conducting fawning interviews with both. What the Maharashtra elections couldn't do, give Thackerays relevance, a few carefully chosen insults did. The same anchors who encouraged Khan to declare his Indianness asked Thackeray why he wanted the actor to wear it on his sleeve. It's the same reason why pretty young women are allowing Rahul Mahajan to feel he is a desi George Clooney on *Rahul Dulhaniya Le Jayenge*. The same motivation that sees long-term girlfriends catch cheating boyfriends on camera even as the sound recordist struggles to keep up with the beeps in *Emosional Atyachar*. The same desire that got Mark David Chapman to shoot John Lennon outside his New York apartment in 1980. Attach yourself to fame, or notoriety, and be validated. It used to be the preserve of the seriously damaged souls. Now it seems everyone needs a couch.

Pay a little attention to the writer that Chapman was reading after he shot Lennon, J.D. Salinger, whose iconic Franny Glass said: "Just because I like applause and people to rave about me, doesn't make it right. I'm sick of not having the courage to be an absolute nobody." Now apply it to Thackeray Junior's growing breed of nobodies. The Attention Seekers who want to compete with the Attention Getters. It's a dangerous spiral in which no one wins as everyone jostles to be seen, to be

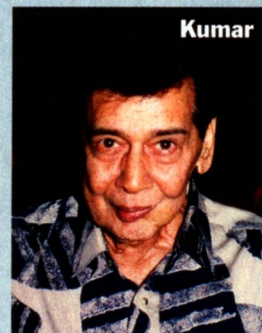
heard, to be discussed in the nighttime bulletins, to be invited to panel discussions on the future of Mumbai, where Rahul Gandhi's visit gets talked up in the same High Anxiety tone as is used to describe Shiv Sena assaults. It's a process that is turning the nobodies into familiar faces, my particular favourite being a woman who was last seen attacking Bhojpuri actor Manoj Tiwari's office under the mistaken impression that he was Manish Tiwari of the Congress.

It's enough to send us all into the hermit crab existence favoured by the late Salinger, especially when faced with the irony of the Shiv Sena's Marathi specialists deploying a brand new fluent-in-English Rahul Narvekar to defend its parochialism. But when a dizzying whirl cannot distinguish good from bad, when film promotions blur into national debates, and when Bollywood stars unwittingly set political agendas, then it's time to examine why even so much talk, on Twitter, TV or blogs, cannot prevent double-speak. And why real achievement is no longer needed in an unreal world.



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Actor and producer **Sujit Kumar**, 75, who starred in films such as *Aradhana*, *Kaamchor* and *Krantiveer*. He was also the first superstar of Bhojpuri cinema.



Kumar

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EXTENDED: By the Central Government, the ban on the **Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI)** by two years, starting February 7. This is the fifth time the ban has been extended since 2001.

DIED: Former Delhi football captain **Mohinder Pal**, who led the team in 1955-56. He played for New Delhi Heroes from 1940-60. He was 85.

DIED: Economist **Kakkadan Nandanath Raj**, 85, an expert in the Planning Commission who was a part of the team that prepared India's first Five-Year Plan. He had been the economic adviser to prime ministers from Jawaharlal Nehru to P.V. Narasimha Rao.

AWARDED: To theatre artist and playwright **Habib Tanvir** and classical vocalist **Pandit Bhimsen Joshi**, the Lifetime Achievement Award by the Delhi Government.

